

BALLET



Louis XIV

Ballet is a graceful type of dance that uses particular positions and steps. It began in Italy but was developed by the French into the style you see today. Louis XIV of France started the first ballet school in 1661. But the dancers in his “ballets” at the French court sang and recited poems! The first true ballet, without words, was not performed until 1789. The basic steps and jumps taught by Louis’ school are still used today—which is why many of them have French names. *Glisser* means to glide, and *pas de chat* means cat step!

Hopping frogs

The *Tales of Beatrix Potter* is an amazing ballet. The dancers wear wonderful costumes and animal masks.



This short, stiff skirt is called a *tutu*. It allows the dancer’s legs to be seen.

Women did not dance in ballets until 1681. Then, they had to wear long, flowing dresses.



First position
(en première)



Second position
(en seconde)



Third position
(en troisième)



Fourth position
(en quatrième)



Fifth position
(en cinquième)

“Turning feet out” takes years of practice.

The five positions

In the 17th century, a ballet teacher named Beauchamps developed five feet positions that enabled dancers to keep their balance and still look elegant. Later, arm positions were added too. Most ballet steps begin or end with one of these positions.